



UPSC CSE 2026

ANTHROPOLOGY OPTIONAL FOUNDATION

TRIBAL INDIA



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7+ Years Experience

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TRIBAL INDIA (Paper 2)

Handout - 3

Syllabus covered in this Handout:

Paper 2_Chapter 6.3:

- Developmental projects and their impact on tribal displacement
- Development of forest policy and tribals.
- Impact of urbanization and industrialization on tribal populations.

6.3 DEVELOPMENTAL PROJECTS AND THEIR IMPACT ON TRIBAL DISPLACEMENT

Development of infrastructure is very much necessary for the growth of a nation. But not everyone benefits from this development. Most of the time the **projects on forest lands** will result in **displacement of tribals** living in the site of construction and that has a huge impact on the lives of the displaced tribes.

MICHEL CERNEA says that Involuntary displacement should be **minimized**. If possible **avoided**. If involuntary displacements are inevitable, then it can be carried out in such a way that the **livelihood of the tribes is protected**. He also says that rehabilitation/resettlement should be “**people centric**” in approach.

MAGNITUDE OF DISPLACEMENT:

Developmental projects like **Dams, Hydro-electric, Nuclear power**, have resulted in the displacement of lakhs of people. The facts show that **tribal population is 8.6% in India, however the projects resulted in displacement of over 50% of the tribes**. This shows that tribal people are disproportionately affected by our developmental policies.

A study conducted by NALINI NEGI and SURATA GANGULY for the University of Bielefeld, Germany (2011) states that around **50 million people** have been **displaced** in India due to **development projects** - of which **40-50% have been tribals**.

Examples of Dam-Induced Displacement:

Eg 1: Polavaram dam in A.P resulted in an estimated displacement of 3 lakh people and majority of them are tribals.

Eg 2- A case in point is the infamous **Narmada eviction**. On 12 December 1979, in spite of widespread protests, the Indian government decided to raise the height of the **Sardar Sarovar dam** on the Narmada river - and to construct 30 major, 135 medium, and 3000 small dams. This, they announced, would **provide water to about 40 million people**, along with irrigation, and electricity to people in the region. To achieve this, **200,000 people were displaced, of whom a majority were Adivasis**.

Examples of Mining-Induced Displacement:

Example 3: Pakri Barwadih Coal Mining Project (Hazaribagh District)

- Operated by **National Thermal Power Corporation (NTPC)** under the **North Karanpura Coalfield**, this project began land acquisition in **2016**.
- It involves **3,319.42 hectares** (8,202 acres) of land, including **1,950.5 ha of farmland**, **643.9 ha of forest land**, and **101.22 ha of settlements**.
- **19 villages**, including Barkagaon, Sonbarsa, Pakri Barwadih, and Deoria Khurd, face displacement.
- Locals received compensation of **Rs 9.85-10.85 lakh per adult**, but many were re-employed only as **contract guards or labourers** on the same land they once owned.
- Promised jobs, especially for women, ended abruptly when associated factories shut down, leaving families jobless again.

Example 4: Chahal Coal Mine, Chhattisgarh

- The **Chahal open-cast coal mine** in **Raigarh district (Chhattisgarh)**, operated by **South Eastern Coalfields Limited (SECL)** since **2003**, displaced about **400 Adivasi (Kawar tribe)** families from **Lath village**, leaving only 56 families behind.
- Their **farmlands and rice fields** were destroyed due to blasting and excavation, leading to **loss of livelihood** and **forced migration**.
- **Mine waste discharged into nearby rivers** caused severe **water contamination**, cutting off access to clean water and fish, both vital to their subsistence.

- Promised **jobs and compensation** under rehabilitation plans remained **only on paper**, leaving villagers without income or land.
- Another case nearby involved **Hindalco Industries**, which **demolished Adivasi homes** for mine expansion without consent or compensation.
- Together, these show how **industrial mining projects** in Chhattisgarh have led to **land alienation, livelihood loss, and erosion of tribal dignity and culture**, turning once self-sufficient Adivasi villages into symbols of displacement.

Impacts of Displacement: (Mention all the problems that we have discussed in previous handout)
Displacement of tribes, especially the involuntary displacement has a huge impact on not only at the socio-cultural level, but also on the psychological state, let's see the impacts in detail.

Impact on Livelihood:

The tribes that had the entire forest lands for themselves, now have to move to the fringes with **no access to the forest or forest produce**. They **lose the natural habitat** that they have been living in for generations.

Impact on Socio-Cultural aspect:

- **Reduction of Collectiveness to Individualistic Attitude:**
 - The displacement has resulted in a reduction of collectiveness and a shift towards individualistic attitudes among the tribes. This has led to a loss of traditional community values and practices.
- **Agriculturalists Forced into Industrial Labor:**
 - Many agriculturalists among the tribes have been forced to become industrial laborers due to their displacement, leading to a loss of traditional livelihoods and agricultural practices.
- **Religious transformation among tribes as a result of displacement:**
 - The displacement has also led to the slow fading away of many ritualistic cultures that were once an integral part of tribal life.
- **Changing Marriage Rules from Endogamy to Exogamy:**
 - The displacement has resulted in changes to marriage rules, with many tribes shifting from endogamy to exogamy due to their displacement.

Impact on Economic aspects:

- **Loss of Access to Forest Produce:**
 - The displacement has resulted in tribes losing access to forest produce, which has been a significant source of livelihood for many tribal communities.
- **Transformation into Landless Peasants:**
 - Many tribes have been turned into landless peasants due to displacement, with their traditional lands being taken away for various development projects.
- **Severe Poverty Among Tribals:**
 - The displacement has hit tribes hard economically, with many facing extreme poverty due to the loss of their traditional livelihoods and lack of access to resources.
- **Shift from Traditional Economic Occupations to Industrial Labor:**
 - Many tribes have been forced to abandon their traditional economic occupations and become industrial laborers due to their displacement.
- **Inadequate Monetary Compensation:**
 - The remuneration granted to tribes for land acquisition, resulting in their displacement, is frequently deemed to be insufficient and delayed, thus exacerbating economic hardships.

Measures taken:

National Rehabilitation and Resettlement Policy, 2007:

- **Objectives:**
 - to **minimize displacement** and to promote, 'as far as possible, non-displacing or least-displacing alternatives;
 - to ensure **adequate rehabilitation package** and expeditious' implementation of the rehabilitation process with the active participation of the affected families;
 - to ensure that special care is taken for **protecting the rights of the weaker sections** of society, especially members of the Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes, and to create obligations on the State for their treatment with concern and sensitivity;
 - to provide a **better standard of living**, making concerted efforts for providing sustainable income to the affected families;
 - to **integrate rehabilitation** concerns **into the development** planning and implementation process;

- and where displacement is on account of land acquisition, to facilitate harmonious relationship between the required body and affected families through **mutual cooperation**.

To conclude, **displacement has always been a companion of development**. But the process should be as **humane** and **voluntary** as possible. The focus of the government should be on **rehabilitation, not just displacement**. And the cost of rehabilitation should be included in the project cost.

6.3 FOREST POLICIES

Tribal-Forest Relationship

The existence of tribal communities is deeply linked with forests. They share a **sympiotic relationship**, depending on forests for food, shelter, fuel, livelihood, and cultural identity. As JRIPATHI (2016) notes, tribes live in a *harmonious and interdependent relationship* with their forest environment. Their economic life, social organisation, and magico-religious beliefs all revolve around the forest ecosystem.

Colonial Period Forest Acts

Forest Act of 1865

- Marked the beginning of formal state control over forests.
- Traditional practices of local people were **restricted by law**.
- Forests were treated as **state property** rather than community resources.

Forest Act of 1878

- Expanded government authority by dividing forests into **Reserved, Protected, and Village Forests**.
- Activities such as **trespassing, grazing, or collecting produce** were prohibited or declared offences.
- Consolidated the power of the **Forest Department** over local use.

First Forest Policy, 1894

- Introduced the idea of “**Eminent Domain**”, giving the state ultimate control over forest land.
- Stated that “**Rights and privileges of individuals must be limited**” in public interest.
- Focused mainly on **revenue generation** and **timber supply** for British needs.

Indian Forest Act, 1927

- Codified previous forest laws into one statute.
- Strengthened the powers of forest officers.
- **Section 64** authorised them to **arrest without warrant** anyone suspected of violating forest laws.
- Continued the **colonial legacy** of exclusion and exploitation rather than conservation.

Post-Independence Forest Policies:

National Forest Policy, 1952

- Continued much of the colonial approach with **limited recognition of tribal rights**.
- Emphasised forests as a **national asset** but ignored the livelihood dependence of local people.
- Tribals were given *concessions* rather than *rights*, maintaining their marginalisation.

National Committee on Development of Backward Areas (1980)

- Recommended that **tribal rights and concessions be fully protected**, and domestic needs be met through forest produce.
- Recognised the importance of forest-based livelihoods for tribal well-being.

B.K. Roy Burman Committee on Forests and Tribals (1982)

- Headed by the eminent anthropologist **B.K. Roy Burman**.
- Highlighted that tribes earn nearly **one-third of their income from minor forest produce**.
- Emphasised the **positive role of forest dwellers** in forest preservation and regeneration.
- Suggested that the **national forest policy** must integrate tribal participation for sustainable forest management.

National Forest Policy, 1988 and Tribal Rights

- Marked a **paradigm shift** from revenue-oriented forestry to **people-oriented forest management**.
- Main objective: *Environmental stability and maintenance of ecological balance*.
- Recognised the **sybiotic relationship** between tribal people and forests.
- Directed that tribal communities should be **actively involved in forest protection, regeneration, and development** (HIREMATH, 1994).
- Introduced the concept of **Joint Forest Management (JFM)**, promoting partnership between Forest Department and local communities.

- Recognised **Minor Forest Produce (MFP)** as a **right** of forest dwellers, not a concession.
- This led to the establishment of cooperatives such as **TRIFED (Tribal Cooperative Marketing Development Federation of India Ltd.)** to market forest produce and eliminate middlemen.

Forest Rights Act, 2006 (FRA): (Covered in detail below, as this can be a separate question in itself)

6.3 b FOREST RIGHTS ACT - 2006

I) Objectives:

- To undo the **historical injustice** occurred to the forest dwelling communities.
- To ensure land tenure, **livelihood** and **food security** of **forest dwelling scheduled tribes and other traditional forest dwellers**.
- To **strengthen the conservation** regime of forests by including the responsibilities and authority on forest by including **sustainable use, conservation of biodiversity and maintenance of ecological balance**.

II) What are the conditions like in the forest areas:

Because of this situation millions of people are subject to harassment, evictions, etc in their own land. Torture, bonded labour, extortion of money, sexual assault are quite common.

III) Why were people's rights not respected?

The Indian Forest act, 1927: India's main forest law had little to do with conservation. It was created to **serve the British need for timber**. It sought to **override customary rights and the forest management** system by declaring **forests as state property** and exploiting their timber.

- A single official is to enquire into and "settle" the disputes regarding land and forest rights that the people had in the area.
- These all powerful officials unsurprisingly either did very little or recorded the rights of powerful communities.

Result:

- The clearing of millions of hectares of forest for **monoculture** plantations by the forest department.
- Moreover the forest laws destroyed all the community management and regulation systems that had existed before, forcing people to choose between **either abandoning the forest** entirely or living as "**criminals**" within or near it.

IV) What does the forest rights act do?

1. **Grants legal recognition** to the rights of traditional forest dwelling communities, partially correcting the injustice caused by forest laws.
2. Makes a beginning towards giving communities and the public a voice in forest and wildlife conservation.

V) Who is a forest dweller under this law, and who gets rights?

There are two stages of eligibility in this act.

First, everyone has to satisfy two conditions:

1. Primarily residing in forests or forest lands.
2. Depend on forests and forest land for livelihood (namely “Bonafide livelihood needs”)

Second, you have to prove:

- That the above conditions have been true for 75 years, in which case you are **another traditional forest dweller**

OR

1. That you are a member of scheduled Tribe
2. That you are residing in the area which is considered as a scheduled area.
3. In latter case you are a **forest dwelling scheduled tribe**

VI) Key Provisions under FRA 2006:

- The law recognises **three types of rights**;
 1. Land rights
 2. Use rights
 3. Rights to protect and conserve.

Land rights:

- No one gets rights to any land that they have not been cultivating **prior to December 13, 2005** and they are not cultivating right now.
- Those who are cultivating land but don't have documents **can claim upto 4 hectares**, as long as they are cultivating land themselves for livelihood.

Use rights:

- They have rights over the collection of **Minor forest produce like tendu, herbs, medicinal plants that were traditionally collected.** (No timber)
- **Grazing grounds and water bodies.**
- Traditional areas of use by nomadic or pastoralist communities i.e, communities that move with their herds, as opposed to practicing settled agriculture.

Right to protect and conserve (Community forest rights):

- For the first time this **law gives the community the rights to protect and manage the forest.**
- **Community Forest Rights (CFR) under FRA 2006:**
 - CFR rights fall under **Section 3(1)(i)** of the *Scheduled Tribes and Other Traditional Forest Dwellers (Recognition of Forest Rights) Act, 2006.*
 - They grant forest-dwelling communities the legal right to **protect, regenerate, conserve, and manage** the forest resources surrounding their villages.
 - However, in several states, the **Forest Department's control-oriented approach** has slowed or obstructed the recognition of CFR claims, undermining community-based forest management.

Positive Case Study - Chhattisgarh and Odisha: Recognising CFR Rights:

- According to official data, **Chhattisgarh has recognised nearly 4,000 Community Forest Rights (CFRs)**, making it one of the most proactive states in India.
- **Kanger Ghati National Park** in Chhattisgarh is the **second national park in India**, after **Simlipal in Odisha**, where CFR rights have been successfully recognised.
- In both **Simlipal** and **Kanger Ghati**, indigenous communities such as those from **Gudiyapadar** have been allowed to **reside within the park** and create **community-led regulations** for sustainable forest use under CFR provisions.
- This model illustrates a **balance between conservation and livelihood rights**, showcasing how local participation can strengthen forest governance.

Negative Case Study - Hasdeo Arand, Chhattisgarh: Revocation of CFR Titles:

- In contrast, the **Hasdeo Aranya region** in Chhattisgarh highlights the **ongoing conflict between development projects and community rights**.
- In **Ghatbarra village**, one of the first villages in the state to receive CFR titles (covering **810 hectares** in 2013), the **District Level Committee revoked the CFR rights in 2016** to facilitate mining operations in the **Parsa East Kete Basen (PEKB) coal block**, operated by a joint venture involving **Adani Enterprises**.
- The **Hasdeo Aranya Bachao Sangharsh Samiti (HABSS)** challenged this revocation in court, arguing it violated both **Gram Sabha consent provisions** and **FRA's core principle** of recognising *pre-existing rights* rather than granting new ones.
- However, the **Chhattisgarh High Court (October 2025)** upheld the revocation on technical grounds, disregarding evidence of Gram Sabha resolutions and community affidavits.
- Activists termed the judgment a **"mockery of the Forest Rights Act"**, warning that it **sets a dangerous precedent** by allowing corporate interests to override legally recognised community rights.
- This case underscores the **gap between law and implementation**, showing how procedural loopholes and bureaucratic interpretations can reverse decades of progress in tribal and forest justice.

• **Particularly Vulnerable Tribal Groups: food security and Habitat rights:**

- In recognition of vulnerability, the FRA has a special provision for PVTGs for "Rights including community tenures of habitat and habitation" under section 3(1)e.
- Habitat-Area - comprising common habitat and such other habitats in reserved forests and protected forests

VII) Implementation Issues of the Forest Rights Act (FRA), 2006

1. High Rejection Rates:

Across states, a large number of **claims under FRA are rejected** due to incomplete documentation, lack of proof of cultivation before **13 December 2005**, or disputes between the **Forest and Revenue Departments**. In **Odisha**, over **1.4 lakh claims** were rejected, and most

states have not completed the review ordered by the **Supreme Court (2019)**. Such arbitrary dismissals have branded genuine forest dwellers as *encroachers*, violating the spirit of the FRA.

2. **Non-Communication of Rejections:**

Rejected applicants are rarely informed in writing, violating **Section 6(2)** of the Act. This denies them the **right to appeal** within 60 days. Absence of clear timelines and irregular meetings of the **State Level Monitoring Committees** add to procedural opacity.

3. **Weak District Support:**

Many **district administrations** fail to provide **revenue or forest maps** to Gram Sabhas. This makes verification of claims difficult and leads to a **gap between land claimed and land granted**.

4. **Faulty Evictions:**

Thousands of families have been **evicted from forest lands** on incomplete or manipulated records. In **Hasdeo Arand (Chhattisgarh)**, the **Ghatbarra village** CFR title was cancelled to allow coal mining, violating due process.

5. **Resistance by Forest Departments:**

Forest officials often **impede CFR recognition** and retain control over forest management. Section **3(1)(i)** of FRA, which mandates community rights to protect and manage forests, is ignored in practice.

- Eg: In **Tamil Nadu, Kattunayakans** (honey collectors) face harassment from forest guards and are prevented from collecting forest produce.

6. **Conflicting Laws and Policies:**

The FRA's intent conflicts with other laws such as the **Forest Conservation Act (1980)**, **Wildlife Protection Act (1972)**, and **CAMPA (2016)**. The **2023 amendment** to FCA now allows activities like **ecotourism and safaris** on forest land without explicit Gram Sabha consent.

7. **Institutional Turf Wars:**

There is poor coordination between the **Ministry of Tribal Affairs (MoTA)** and the **Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change (MoEFCC)**. This inter-ministerial friction delays implementation and causes contradictory directions at state level.

8. **Procedural Violations:**

Claims are often rejected by **Forest Guards or Patwaris** who have **no legal authority** to do so. In places like **Chhattorgarh**, rejections were made orally without notice, preventing any appeal process.

9. **Data Manipulation and Errors:**

In **Chhattisgarh**, reports by **ATREE** found duplicate entries and inflated data. Only **243 Gram Sabhas** actually received community rights though records claimed 1,378.

10. **Lack of Awareness:**

Many **Gram Sabha members and OTFDs** lack awareness about FRA provisions. Meetings are often postponed, and claims delayed indefinitely. Despite portals like **Adi Prashikshan**, awareness remains low in remote areas.

11. **Judicial Uncertainty:**

The **2019 Supreme Court eviction order** created panic among 1.8 million forest dwellers. Although the order was stayed, most states are yet to review rejected claims properly.

12. **Protected Area Displacement:**

Over **1 lakh forest dwellers** have been displaced from tiger reserves due to **NTCA relocations**, without settling their FRA claims. This reflects a **conservation-vs-rights conflict**.

13. **Mining and Clearance Violations:**

Forest clearances are granted before FRA compliance. The **Hasdeo Arand case** (Adani-operated mine) showed cancellation of CFR titles without Gram Sabha consent, termed by activists as a **“mockery of FRA.”**

14. **Uneven State Progress:**

Only **Maharashtra (36%)**, **Chhattisgarh (24%)**, and **Odisha (10%)** have recognised substantial **CFR rights**. Other major states remain nearly at **zero recognition**, showing administrative neglect.

VIII) Significance and Achievements of FRA

1. **Historical Justice:**

FRA corrects the **“historical injustice”** faced by Scheduled Tribes and forest dwellers under colonial forest laws, recognising both **Individual Forest Rights (IFR)** and **Community Forest Rights (CFR/CFRR)**.

2. **Comprehensive Rights:**

Sections **3(1)(b)**, **3(1)(c)**, and **3(1)(i)** legally empower communities to access, occupy, and manage forest lands, water bodies, grazing areas, and biodiversity resources.

3. **Empowered Gram Sabhas:**

FRA makes **Gram Sabhas** the central authority for claim verification and forest governance, promoting **participatory democracy** at the local level.

4. **Community Stewardship Successes:**

Villages like **Mendha Lekha (Maharashtra)** and **Betakata (Odisha)** formed **CFR Management Committees (CFRMCs)** that sustainably regulate forest use, prevent illegal felling, and conserve biodiversity.

5. **Economic Empowerment:**

Recognition of bamboo and NTFP rights has raised incomes. In **Pajilibandha and Kalakani (Odisha)**, women now earn **₹5,000-6,000 per month** through **Van Dhan Kendras**, showing how FRA links livelihoods with conservation.

6. **Ecological Benefits:**

CFR villages like **Soura Kurlanda** have restored degraded forests and increased biodiversity, showing that **community control enhances conservation**.

7. **Gender and PVTG Inclusion:**

Women and **Particularly Vulnerable Tribal Groups (PVTGs)** participate in **Van Suraksha Samitis**, ensuring equitable access and decision-making power.

8. **Link with PESA:**

States like **Odisha and Maharashtra** have merged FRA implementation with **PESA**, giving **legal corporate status** to Gram Sabhas under **Article 243G**, enabling self-rule.

9. **Technological Innovation:**

In **Gujarat's Narmada district**, NGOs used **GPS and satellite imagery** to create digital maps for accurate claim verification, now replicated in other states.

10. **Administrative Achievements:**

As per **MoTA (2024)**, about **60% of total claims** have been recognised, covering **13 million acres** of land. This marks steady progress in a complex, multi-tiered process.

11. **Model for Sustainable Governance:**

When implemented properly, FRA balances **livelihood security with biodiversity conservation**, offering a **global model** of justice-based environmental management.

IX) Way Forward and Suggestions

1. **Review Rejected Claims:**

States must **review all rejected claims** transparently, issue written reasons for rejection, and ensure **appeal rights** under Section 6.

2. **Strengthen Gram Sabhas:**

Recognise Gram Sabhas as **body corporates** (as in Maharashtra and Odisha) for fund management, decision-making, and legal representation.

3. **Joint Institutional Coordination:**

Establish **joint MoTA-MoEFCC mechanisms** for consistent interpretation of forest and tribal policies.

4. **Digital Mapping Tools:**

Adopt **GPS and GIS mapping** for claims to eliminate duplication and manipulation of data, with assistance from **BISAG and NRSC**.

5. **Awareness and Training:**

Expand **Tribal Research Institutes** and **Adi Prashikshan**-like platforms for grassroots legal and procedural training of FRCs and community leaders.

6. **Livelihood Integration:**

Link **CFR areas with livelihood schemes** such as **TRIFED, Van Dhan Yojana**, and **PM-JANMAN**, to ensure forest-based income and self-reliance.

7. **Legal Safeguards:**

Mandate **Gram Sabha consent** before approving mining or diversion projects to prevent FRA violations like in **Hasdeo Arand**.

8. **Inclusive Participation:**

Encourage **women, PVTGs, and marginal groups** in decision-making and forest management to ensure inclusive governance.

9. **Monitoring and Transparency:**

Create **state-level dashboards** to publish data on claims filed, approved, and pending. Promote **real-time accountability** among district committees.

10. **Model Replication:**

Scale up successful models from **Mendha Lekha** and **Betakata**, and promote **peer learning** through exposure visits across states.

11. **Policy Convergence:**

Integrate FRA with national programmes like **Green India Mission**, **CAMPA**, and **National Biodiversity Strategy**, ensuring that **livelihood and conservation goals** move together.

12. **National FRA Mission:**

Launch a **dedicated National FRA Mission** with a separate budget and time-bound targets for claim settlement, as proposed in recent **Parliament discussions**.

X) Current issues of importance:

Supreme court order:

- On feb 13, 2019, the **Supreme court** ordered the **eviction** of lakhs belonging to the **scheduled Tribes (STs)** and **other traditional forest dwellers (OTFDs)** categories across 16 states, **whose claim as forest-dwellers has been rejected under forest rights act**.
- A bench of judges ordered the chief secretaries of these states to evict those whose claims were finally rejected.
- The court directed that the evidence be carried out by July 24, 2019.
- On feb 28, the court stayed its order though it said **“The mighty and the undeserving”** who have encroached on forest land would be shown no mercy.
- The stay in the order was due to the **role of Anthropologists and activists** in raising **awareness** about the **real reasons for the high rejection rates**, and also due to **protests from tribes**.
- It has decided to examine whether due processes were followed by the **gram sabhas and the states under the forest rights act** before the claims were rejected.

In conclusion, the **Forest Rights Act (2006)** stands as a landmark in **ecological justice and tribal empowerment**, but its promise is yet to be fully realised due to weak implementation, bureaucratic hurdles, and conflicting conservation priorities. To achieve its full potential, India must strengthen **Gram**

Sabhas, ensure **legal accountability**, and make **community-led forest governance** the foundation of sustainable forest management.

Transition from Colonial Forest Control to Community-Based Governance in Independent India:

The evolution of forest policy in India represents a **transition from coercive control to participatory conservation**.

1. From Control to Custodianship:

Early forest laws (1865-1927) aimed at asserting state power and revenue extraction, while post-1988 and 2006 frameworks recognise **tribal custodianship of forests**.

2. From Bureaucratic Management to Community Governance:

The colonial and early post-independence models relied on **top-down bureaucracy**, but modern laws like the **FRA (2006)** empower **Gram Sabhas** as democratic forest managers.

3. From Exploitation to Ecological Justice:

The shift also marks India's movement from **extractive forestry** to **rights-based environmental justice**, acknowledging that **conservation without community participation is unsustainable**.

4. From Economic Utility to Ecological Balance:

The **1988 policy** reframed forests not as economic resources but as **ecological assets**, paving the way for **joint forest management** and **community forest rights**.

5. Persisting Contradictions:

Despite progressive intent, old administrative mindsets persist. Conflicts between **MoTA and MoEFCC**, and between **conservation and livelihood priorities**, continue to challenge policy implementation.

6. The Way Ahead:

The success of India's forest governance now depends on **bridging these historical contradictions**, ensuring that **tribal stewardship and ecological conservation coexist** through genuine decentralisation and capacity building.

In conclusion, forest policies in India reflect a journey from **colonial domination to democratic participation**. The **Forest Rights Act (2006)** embodies this transformation by recognising forest dwellers as partners in conservation rather than intruders. Yet, for its promise to be fulfilled, India must ensure effective implementation, community awareness, and strong Gram Sabha empowerment, so that **justice, sustainability, and livelihood security** truly reach those who live by the forest.

Climate Pressures on India's Forest-Dwelling Communities:

India's tribal and indigenous communities are among the **strongest protectors of forests and biodiversity**, yet they face the **severest impacts of climate change**. Their livelihoods, food systems, and cultural traditions are being reshaped by ecological disruption.

1. Risks and Problems due to Climate Change

Tribal livelihoods are highly climate-sensitive because they depend on forests, rainfall, and soil fertility.

- **Erratic monsoons and droughts** threaten cultivation and forest produce. The **Bhil** community in Gujarat, once praying for rain, now faces destructive floods followed by prolonged dry spells.
- **Shrinking forests and biodiversity loss** reduce access to minor forest produce such as tendu, mahua, and bamboo, undermining income and food security.
- **Soil erosion and deforestation** worsen migration, especially in Central India, while extreme heat and forest fires endanger both crops and health.

2. Coping through Tribal Ecological Knowledge

Indigenous communities apply **traditional ecological knowledge (TEK)** to adapt to environmental stress and sustain ecosystems.

- **Jarawa (Andaman Islands):** Predict cyclones by observing fish movement and sea behaviour, enabling timely evacuation and disaster preparedness.
- **Khasi (Meghalaya):** Practise community agroforestry and maintain *sacred groves*, preserving soil moisture and biodiversity in high-rainfall zones.
- **Apatani (Arunachal Pradesh):** Use rice-fish integrated farming in the Ziro Valley, conserving water and enhancing soil fertility without chemicals.
- **Dongria Kondh (Odisha) and Irular (Tamil Nadu):** Follow organic multi-crop farming with traditional pest control and seed-saving, ensuring food and ecological security.
- **Zabo System (Nagaland):** Combines rainwater harvesting, forestry, animal husbandry, and agriculture to maintain fertility and reduce drought stress.

These practices show how TEK strengthens community resilience, conserves biodiversity, and supports sustainable adaptation to climate change.

3. Continuing Struggles and Policy Disconnect

Despite their ecological wisdom, tribal communities remain **marginalised in climate governance**.

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- National programmes such as **CAMPA** and the **Green India Mission** are largely top-down and have led to “**green displacement**” through afforestation without community consent.
- **Gender inequalities** are widening, as tribal women bear the burden of resource collection and loss of autonomy.
- Traditional rain forecasting and shifting cultivation cycles are failing as climate shifts become unpredictable, eroding both livelihoods and ancestral knowledge.
- **Institutional fragmentation** between MoTA and MoEFCC and the neglect of **Gram Sabha consent** under FRA weaken adaptation from below.

4. Path Ahead: Integrating Rights and Resilience

A sustainable future demands that **traditional knowledge and modern science work together**.

- Integrate **FRA (2006)** and **PESA (1996)** into climate-adaptation frameworks and link them with schemes like **PM JANMAN**.
- Empower **Gram Sabhas** to manage eco-restoration and climate funds locally.
- Document and scale up models such as **Zabo** and **Apatani** systems across eco-regions.
- Strengthen the role of **tribal women and PVTGs** in decision-making and climate planning.
- Blend **community forecasting techniques** with modern satellite-based early-warning systems for better preparedness.

The people who **nurture and protect India’s natural ecosystems** are the ones **most endangered by climate change**. Their survival depends not only on external support but on recognising them as **equal partners in climate adaptation and forest governance**. Building climate resilience in India must begin with strengthening the rights, knowledge, and institutions of those who live by the forest.

6.3 INDUSTRIALIZATION AND URBANIZATION

The tribal lands are not only **rich in forest resources** but also contain **rich mineral deposits**. The post-independence government of India, with **development** as the center or focus, tried to **exploit the minerals for raw materials** and **constructed many projects** in the tribal lands.

This development was supposed to uplift the tribals, but that did not happen. Instead, the industrial and developmental projects have **uprooted the tribals from their dwellings**. They were deprived of their land and **were paid meager cash**, which they used up eventually. These development projects made them **landless and moneyless**.

Industrialization and tribals:

The mineral rich tribal lands have attracted **mining projects**. Due to mining, the forests started to disappear. The projects **acquired more land** than is required, which is then used for **private housing** in many places, leaving the original landowners destitute. Despite the rules providing for a **90 percent reservation for locals in employment and training**, government figures show that the **reality has been exactly the opposite**. Outsiders continue to be given preferential treatment in matters of employment and **land alienation** continues uninterrupted. So this made the poor tribal to go out searching for employment and eventually become **industrial labor or some other unskilled labor** living in the nearby towns and living in the outskirts slums.

Case Study 1: Pakri Barwadih Coal Mining Project (Hazaribagh District)

- Operated by **National Thermal Power Corporation (NTPC)** under the **North Karanpura Coalfield**, this project began land acquisition in **2016**.
- It involves **3,319.42 hectares** (8,202 acres) of land, including **1,950.5 ha of farmland**, **643.9 ha of forest land**, and **101.22 ha of settlements**.
- **19 villages**, including Barkagaon, Sonbarsa, Pakri Barwadih, and Deoria Khurd, face displacement.
- Locals received compensation of **Rs 9.85-10.85 lakh per adult**, but many were re-employed only as **contract guards or labourers** on the same land they once owned.
- Promised jobs, especially for women, ended abruptly when associated factories shut down, leaving families jobless again.
- Altogether, mining companies have acquired **over 87,000 hectares** of land in Jharkhand, that's larger than the entire city of Bengaluru.
- Most of these lands belonged to **Scheduled Tribes** and **Scheduled Castes**. Skilled jobs in the mines often go to **migrants from other states**, while locals are left unemployed or forced to migrate in search of work.
- Even though Jharkhand's **2008 Rehabilitation and Resettlement Policy** promised that locals would benefit first, in reality, the **tribals lost both land and livelihood**.

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Case Study 2: Chaal Coal Mine, Chhattisgarh

- The **Chaal open-cast coal mine** in **Raigarh district (Chhattisgarh)**, operated by **South Eastern Coalfields Limited (SECL)** since **2003**, displaced about **400 Adivasi (Kawar tribe)** families from **Lath village**, leaving only 56 families behind.
- Their **farmlands and rice fields** were destroyed due to blasting and excavation, leading to **loss of livelihood** and **forced migration**.
- **Mine waste discharged into nearby rivers** caused severe **water contamination**, cutting off access to clean water and fish, both vital to their subsistence.
- Promised **jobs and compensation** under rehabilitation plans remained **only on paper**, leaving villagers without income or land.
- Another case nearby involved **Hindalco Industries**, which **demolished Adivasi homes** for mine expansion without consent or compensation.
- Together, these show how **industrial mining projects** in Chhattisgarh have led to **land alienation, livelihood loss, and erosion of tribal dignity and culture**, turning once self-sufficient Adivasi villages into symbols of displacement.

Urbanization: Why and How?

Due to the setting up of developmental projects in the tribal lands, the natives living there have to be **resettled** to some other place. This made them **lose access to the forest, its resources, their agricultural land, their whole livelihood**. So, in order to earn the bread, they venture out to the nearest town. Poor tribals who formerly lived in a secluded culture must now **adapt to a cosmopolitan** society without access to education, equipment, or resources. There is an identity issue. Life in town is also difficult; people are forced to build and live in **filthy slums on the outskirts**. These slums, of course, lack basic amenities such as tap water, drainage, garbage disposal etc.

Yes, of course in the initial stages a good number of tribals got employment in unskilled jobs but once the construction work came to an end they found themselves **unsuitable for skilled and semi-skilled jobs**. These skilled jobs were taken up by outsiders who would eventually settle in tribal lands, whereas the tribals were driven off to fringes of forests as “**rejects**”.

Case Study: Madhya Pradesh - Encroachment and Forest Loss

Madhya Pradesh has India's **largest tribal population**, about **15% of its total**. It is divided into two belts:

- **Western Tribal Belt** (dominated by Bhil tribes - 49%)
- **Eastern Tribal Belt** (dominated by Gonds - 36%)

But Madhya Pradesh also leads the country in **forest land encroachment**, with over **5,347 square kilometers** lost, the highest in India.

In **2022**, a shocking incident took place in **Shahdol district**.

A tribal man named **Dhyan Singh** committed suicide after the **forest department demolished his hut**, claiming he had encroached on **0.010 hectares** of forest land, barely a few meters.

The irony is that he had already received money under the **Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana (PMAY)** to build that very house.

The department justified its action under **Section 36(1) of the Indian Forest Act, 1927**, but for Dhyan Singh, it meant losing his only shelter.

Impacts:

Industrialization and urbanization have been major agents of socio-economic transformation in post-independence India. While these processes created industries, infrastructure, and employment, they also caused widespread dislocation and cultural disintegration among tribal communities. Tribal areas, being rich in minerals, forests, and water, became the focal points of development projects. However, these projects often displaced the original inhabitants, disrupting their traditional way of life.

According to Das and BANERJI ⁽¹⁹⁶⁴⁾, the impact of industrialization and urbanization on tribals can be studied under four major dimensions - **social, economic, religious, and psychological**, each reflecting deep structural changes in tribal society.

1. SOCIAL IMPACTS:

a) Loss of Home and Forests

For tribal communities, forests represent both livelihood and identity. They provide food, fuel, medicinal plants, and materials for shelter, while also holding cultural and spiritual significance. With the expansion of mining, dam, and industrial projects, these forests have been rapidly depleted.

Data from the Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change shows that **Madhya Pradesh alone lost 219.7 hectares of forest land** to infrastructure projects, forming **about 24 percent of India's total forest diversion** over the last decade.

The disappearance of forests deprives tribals of their economic base and sacred landscapes. The destruction of sacred groves and ecological systems also weakens traditional beliefs and community bonds. The result is large-scale displacement, land alienation, and loss of cultural stability.

b) Resources Exploited but Tribals Left Behind

Although tribal regions contribute significantly to the national economy through mineral extraction, the benefits seldom reach local populations. The **Keonjhar district of Odisha**, one of India's richest in iron ore and manganese, presents a clear example.

Despite its mineral wealth, Keonjhar suffers from severe malnutrition and poor health indicators:

- Over **13 lakh children** are **stunted or underweight**.
- **74.7 percent of pregnant women** are **anaemic**.
- **25.9 percent of women** have a **low Body Mass Index (BMI)** (NFHS-5).

This disparity shows that economic development in these regions primarily benefits corporations and outsiders, while the tribal inhabitants remain impoverished and marginalized.

c) Breakdown of Family and Kinship

Das and Banerji (1964) observed that industrialization and migration have weakened interpersonal ties within tribal families. Earlier, the **joint family system** was the norm, ensuring collective ownership of land and strong kinship relations.

Migration to industrial areas has resulted in the fragmentation of these families into **nuclear units**, weakening traditional authority structures. Elders no longer hold the same decision-making power, and the younger generation increasingly adopts individualistic values.

The rise in **divorces**, **inter-community marriages**, and the decline in community-level festivals and rituals reflect a shift from collective cultural life to isolated urban existence. The overall result has been the erosion of kinship solidarity and the weakening of community cohesion.

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2. ECONOMIC IMPACTS

a) Shift in Occupation

Before industrialization, tribals depended on **subsistence agriculture, hunting, fishing, and forest collection**, with the family functioning as the basic unit of production. Industrialization disrupted this pattern by introducing **individual wage labour** in factories, mines, and construction sites.

This transformation changed not only the mode of production but also the nature of work. Factory employment is characterized by **rigid hours, repetitive tasks, and impersonal relations**, contrasting with the flexible and communal nature of traditional tribal work. Tribals, being accustomed to seasonal agricultural cycles, often find industrial work monotonous and emotionally draining.

As Das and Banerji noted, labour among tribals has shifted from being a collective social activity to an individual economic necessity.

b) Unemployment and Casual Labour

Despite promises of local employment, industrial projects in tribal areas have rarely provided sustainable jobs to displaced families. The majority of skilled and semi-skilled positions are occupied by **non-tribal workers**, while tribals are employed temporarily as **unskilled labourers**.

After project completion, these jobs vanish, leaving many families without income or land.

As a result, migration to urban centres has increased. Tribals often end up as **construction workers, street vendors, or domestic helpers**, living in poor urban settlements without sanitation, clean water, or healthcare.

This shift represents a movement from a self-sufficient agrarian lifestyle to economic dependency and urban poverty.

3. RELIGIOUS IMPACTS

Industrialization and urbanization have led to a gradual decline in tribal religious and ritual life. Rituals connected to agriculture, harvest, and forest worship are now either shortened or discontinued.

According to **Das and Banerji (1964)**, the simplification of traditional ceremonies has occurred largely due to **financial hardship** and **lack of leisure** in urban or industrial settings.

Community shrines and sacred groves are often inaccessible after displacement, which weakens traditional belief systems. The absence of ritual spaces and collective participation has further contributed to the breakdown of communal and spiritual identity among displaced tribals.

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4. PSYCHOLOGICAL IMPACTS

The psychological consequences of industrialization and urbanization are both severe and long-lasting. Displacement, loss of land, and cultural alienation create a deep sense of insecurity and helplessness. Individuals who once lived as independent cultivators or forest gatherers are now dependent on employers or contractors. The resulting **loss of control over their own lives** often leads to **low self-esteem, frustration, and anxiety**.

Das and Banerji described this as the emergence of a sense of **powerlessness** among tribal populations. The younger generation, disconnected from their traditional culture, faces identity crises and higher vulnerability to substance abuse. These conditions signify the breakdown not only of economic security but also of psychological well-being.

5. POSITIVE IMPACTS

Despite the numerous adverse effects, some positive outcomes have emerged from tribal contact with modern society. Industrialization has indirectly facilitated the spread of **education, healthcare, and infrastructure** in several tribal regions.

Exposure to new ideas has led to gradual **social reform**, as seen in the declining acceptance of practices like **witch-hunting, child marriage, and gender-based taboos**.

Additionally, traditional art and craft forms have gained national and international recognition. **Gond paintings** from Madhya Pradesh and **Warli art** from Maharashtra have become symbols of indigenous creativity and are now promoted through cultural organizations and cooperatives.

Several NGOs and self-help groups assist tribal communities in marketing **handicrafts, forest produce, and traditional goods**, enabling economic empowerment and cultural preservation.

Thus, to summarize, Industrialization and urbanization have brought both development and destruction to India's tribal societies.

While these processes have expanded infrastructure and created new economic opportunities, they have also displaced millions, dismantled traditional social systems, and eroded cultural values.

The need of the hour is to ensure **inclusive and participatory development**, where tribal communities are treated as **partners rather than victims**. Sustainable development must integrate **economic growth with cultural preservation** and guarantee that the rights and welfare of tribal populations are not compromised in the pursuit of modernization.

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